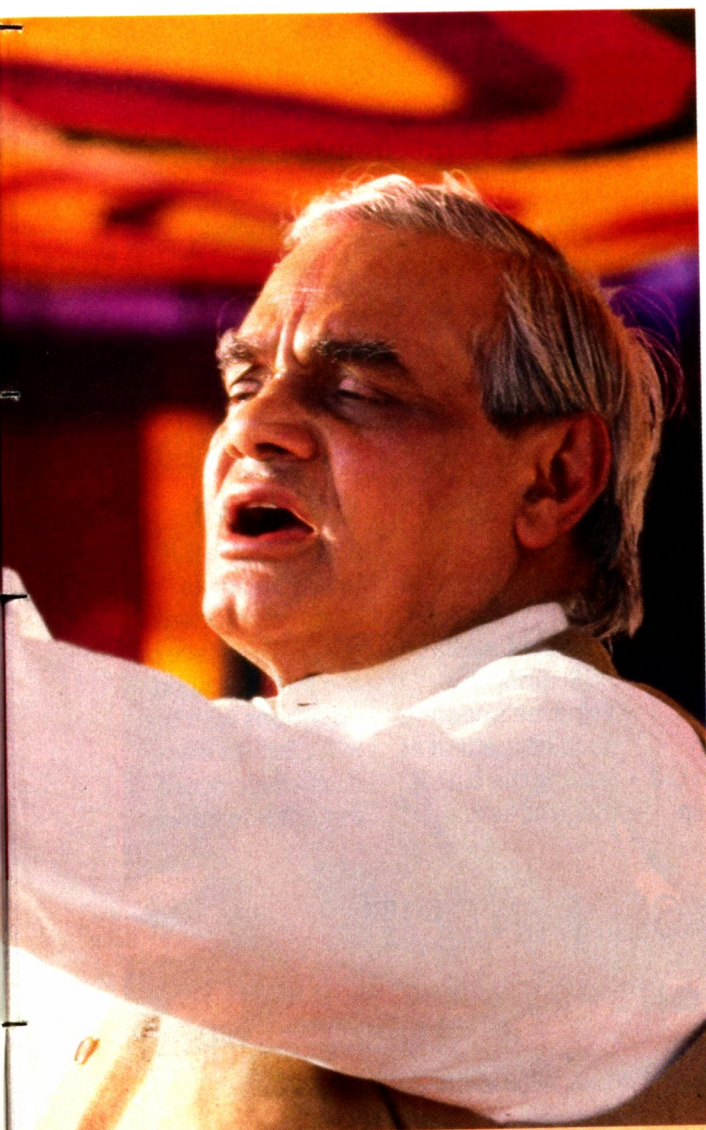




**VAJPAYEE WAS LARGER THAN THE PARTY AND A LEADER OF GRAND GESTURES. HE WAS THE UNIFIER AS WELL AS THE RECONCILER**

face of the Indian Right—call him the BJP's Dubcek. Moderation, reconciliation and freedom of dissent—those were the principles he refused to abandon throughout his tenure at the South Block. Still, his authority remained unchallenged. Today, it is as if there is no place for gentlemen in a party that gave us a gentleman prime minister with a moral value system. The BJP lacks everything that Vajpayee represents. It badly needs a leader who has the mind to restore the ideas of Vajpayee. Its leaders seem to have only one idea—and it is all about their own survival, not the party's. Vajpayee won't miss the party.

YASBANT NEGI



**SUSHMA SWARAJ IS THE ULTIMATE FENCE-SITTER WITH MORE ACCEPTABILITY THAN MOST**

was his last chance of redemption. Perhaps he alone could have averted Jaswant's martyrdom. Advani, the first BJP leader to sing the secular virtues of Mohammad Ali Jinnah, quietly endorsed the banishment of the blasphemous Jaswant who did not say anything more outrageous than what the leader of the Opposition had written in the visitor's book at Jinnah's mausoleum in Karachi: "His (Jinnah's) August 11, 1947, address is a forceful espousal of a secular state in which every citizen would be free to practice his own religion. My respectful homage to this great man." Well, Jaswant did a lot more than lazily paraphrasing the Quaid-e-Azam's much quoted address to the Constituent Assembly of Pakistan. He did 10 years of research in history before retelling the story of Partition and the political life of Jinnah. When Jaswant was summarily sacked by the suddenly animated Rajnath Singh for writing a book, for going against the popular mythology of the good Nehru and Patel and the evil Jinnah, for asking questions. Ideally, Advani should have stood up for the sacredness arguments.

Certainly he could not have been unaware of the uses of arguments and revaluation of the past in a confident democracy that was in no need of bogeymen. Advani too suffered for his arguments for a while; he felt abandoned, isolated and misunderstood, but he stood by his belief. He did not repent or recant. When INDIA TODAY chose him as the Newsmaker of the Year in the aftermath of his rendezvous with the secular Jinnah, he told the magazine: "When I look back, I identify two landmark events in my entire political career: first, the Rath Yatra from Somnath to Ayodhya; second, the six-day trip to Pakistan. And I can tell you that... I had a feeling I was making history. The Rath Yatra yielded immediate dividends for the party. As for the Pakistan trip, a few years down the line there will be people who will